

LONG-NECKED BEAST

ALBERTONECTES

While many of the large marine reptiles known as plesiosaurs are famous for having long necks, *Albertonectes* took this trait to the extreme. Reaching lengths of 23 ft (7 m), its elongated neck had the most bones of any known animal. *Albertonectes* was one of the last plesiosaurs to evolve before the mass extinction at the end of the Mesozoic Era. It cruised through the Western Interior Seaway—an inland sea that divided the continent of North America into two parts—during the Late Cretaceous Period. As it swam the shallow waters, it used its small head and long neck to catch fish and other marine organisms.

STATS AND FACTS

About 97 stones, some weighing up to 2 lb (1 kg), have been found among *Albertonectes*'s stomach fossils. Some of these came from beaches and riverbanks, which suggests that this creature patrolled the shorelines.

NECK BONES



Albertonectes had a record-breaking 76 bones in its neck. Its closest relatives had between 46 and 71.

SWIMMING STYLE



Albertonectes swam by moving its flippers up and down in the water like wings.

Uncertain use

Exactly why some plesiosaurs evolved such immense necks is still unknown, and after more than 200 years of study, paleontologists are still debating this question. Short-necked plesiosaurs would have been more flexible than *Albertonectes*, which suggests that it may have adopted a unique hunting style to accommodate its long neck.

No fossils of *Albertonectes*'s head have been found, but paleontologists think it may have looked like other plesiosaurs.